
From Multidimensional Perception to Revisit Intention: The Roles of Cognitive Image and Satisfaction among Chinese Tourists Visiting South Korea

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Abstract: Over the past decade, Chinese outbound tourism has become one of the most influential source markets in global tourism. Against this backdrop, South Korea has emerged as an important short-haul destination for Chinese tourists. Drawing on user-generated content (UGC) and survey data, this study examines how multidimensional perceptions of South Korea shape destination cognitive image, tourist satisfaction, and revisit intention. First, 12,328 online reviews posted by Chinese tourists between 2015 and 2024 were collected and analyzed through text mining to identify five core perceptual dimensions: romance, culture, history, landscape, and consumption. Second, an online survey of 578 Chinese visitors to South Korea was used to test the proposed model through PLS-SEM. The results show that all five perceptual dimensions positively influence cognitive image and satisfaction. Perceived culture and perceived history exert relatively stronger effects on cognitive image, whereas perceived romance and perceived history more strongly enhance satisfaction. Both cognitive image and satisfaction positively predict revisit intention, but the path from cognitive image to satisfaction is not significant. Mediation analysis further indicates that cognitive image and satisfaction function as parallel rather than sequential mediators between multidimensional perception and revisit intention. The study extends destination image research by integrating UGC-based perceptual dimensions into a unified perception-cognition-behavior framework and offers practical implications for destination marketing directed at the Chinese market.

Keywords: Chinese outbound tourism; South Korea; destination image; user-generated content; PLS-SEM; revisit intention

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1 Introduction

Over the past decade, Chinese outbound tourism has become one of the most influential source markets in the global tourism industry. The number of Chinese outbound tourists reached 146 million, and related spending approached USD 290.4 billion, demonstrating strong travel demand and substantial purchasing power. This growth reflects not only sustained economic development and rising household incomes, but also continuing improvements in the institutional environment, which have gradually transformed outbound travel from a luxury enjoyed by a few into a routine form of mass consumption. Policy adjustments, including the relaxation of outbound travel restrictions and changes in work and leave arrangements, have further released leisure time and travel demand, thereby expanding the scale of China's outbound tourism and reinforcing its importance in the global tourism landscape.

In this context, South Korea has become an important short-haul destination for Chinese tourists because of its geographic proximity, transportation convenience, and cultural affinity. These conditions provide South Korea with a realistic basis for attracting Chinese outbound tourists. However, amid intensifying competition among global destinations and increasingly diversified information channels, resource endowments alone are no longer sufficient to sustain destination competitiveness. How to construct a clear, positive, and attractive destination image through effective destination marketing, and thereby influence tourists' perceptions and decisions, has become a key concern for destination management organizations (DMOs). Existing studies show that destination image plays a central role in tourist decision-making by directly shaping destination choice, experience evaluation, and subsequent behavioral intention.

From a theoretical perspective, travel motivation and destination image provide an important analytical framework for understanding tourist behavior. Push–pull theory suggests that travel decisions are jointly driven by internal motives, such as escape from daily life, relaxation, and novelty seeking, and by external attractions, such as natural scenery, cultural resources, and consumption opportunities. These factors influence not only the decision to travel, but also tourists' overall cognitive and affective evaluations of a destination. Previous research further shows that destination image typically consists of both cognitive and affective dimensions and influences revisit and recommendation intentions through variables such as satisfaction. Nevertheless, the existing literature has not fully integrated cognitive and affective components or systematically explained how multidimensional perceptions develop into an overall destination image, especially across the full process linking perception, cognition, and behavioral intention.

At the same time, digital technologies and social media have substantially transformed the way tourists obtain information. User-generated content (UGC) has gradually become an important information source affecting travel decisions. Compared with traditional destination marketing communications, UGC is more authentic and contextualized, allowing potential visitors to form preliminary understandings of destinations through the experiences of other travelers. Yet prior research has not fully clarified how multidimensional perceptions reflected in UGC further influence satisfaction and behavioral intention through cognitive image. This mechanism therefore requires deeper investigation.

Against this background and in response to the identified research gaps, this study develops an analytical framework of “multidimensional perception–cognitive image–satisfaction–revisit intention” in the context of Chinese tourists visiting South Korea. By systematically organizing and summarizing online travel-review data, the study first identifies the core perceptual dimensions of Chinese tourists' travel experiences in South Korea. It then applies structural equation modeling to examine the effects of these perceptual dimensions on cognitive image and to test the mechanism through which cognitive image influences revisit intention via satisfaction. The study aims to reveal the internal logic through which specific experience-based perceptions are translated into overall cognition and then into behavioral intention.

Accordingly, this study addresses three research questions. First, along which dimensions do Chinese tourists perceive South Korea as a tourism destination? Second, how do these perceptual dimensions shape tourists' cognitive image of South Korea? Third, does destination image further affect revisit intention through satisfaction? By addressing these questions, the study not only extends destination image research in the context of short-haul cross-border tourism, but also provides empirical

evidence for image optimization and destination marketing strategy in the Chinese market.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Travel Motivation and Destination Choice

Tourism motivation has long been a central theoretical starting point for explaining tourists' travel decisions. Classical research argues that tourism behavior is not random, but rather driven by both internal psychological needs and the external attractiveness of destinations. The push–pull framework proposed by Crompton (1979) remains one of the most influential analytical models in tourism research. On the one hand, tourists are pushed by factors such as escape from routine life, relaxation, novelty seeking, and social interaction. On the other hand, they are pulled by destination attributes such as natural scenery, cultural resources, historical heritage, shopping environments, and entertainment facilities (Marine-Roig, 2019). Travel motivation therefore shapes not only whether people travel, but also why they choose a specific destination.

Subsequent studies have further shown that push and pull motivations are not isolated forces; rather, they are closely related to tourists' cognitive expectations and emotional anticipations of destinations. Before departure, tourists form preliminary perceptions of destinations through personal experience, media exposure, and social communication, and these perceptions are continuously revised and reinforced during travel (Khairani & Setyowardhani, 2013). Accordingly, research on travel motivation has gradually moved beyond a narrow focus on motives *per se* toward a broader explanation of the dynamic “motivation–cognition–behavior” process.

2.2 Structural Dimensions and Formation Mechanisms of Destination Image

Destination image is another core concept in tourism research and is widely used to explain tourists' overall evaluations of destinations and their behavioral tendencies. Mainstream studies generally conceptualize destination image as a multidimensional construct composed of cognitive image and affective image. Cognitive image mainly reflects tourists' rational assessments of destination attributes, such as landscape quality, cultural resources, infrastructure, and service standards, whereas affective image captures emotional responses generated during contact with and experience of the destination, such as pleasure, excitement, and relaxation (Baloglu & Mangaloglu, 2001; Hosany et al., 2007).

Although the cognitive–affective structure has been widely accepted, the extant literature still has important limitations. Some studies treat destination image as a holistic construct without clearly distinguishing the different effects of its cognitive and affective components. Other studies emphasize the distinction between the two, but do not further explain how cognitive image is gradually formed from perceptions of specific destination attributes (Qu et al., 2011). In other words, the existing literature pays greater attention to the outcome effects of destination image than to its antecedent mechanisms, especially the process through which multidimensional attribute perceptions are transformed into an overall cognitive image.

This limitation is particularly salient in the context of short-haul cross-border travel. For Chinese tourists, travel decisions involving neighboring countries and regions often combine functional and symbolic considerations. Tourists evaluate tangible attributes such as transportation convenience, consumption environments, and landscape resources, while also being influenced by cultural proximity, media symbols, and popular-cultural imagination. The formation of destination image therefore needs to be examined at a more fine-grained attribute level.

2.3 Destination Image, Satisfaction, and Behavioral Intention

Research on tourist behavioral outcomes suggests that destination image is not a static perception. Rather, it is continually generated through the interaction of pre-travel expectations, on-site experiences, and post-travel evaluations, and ultimately influences satisfaction, revisit intention, and recommendation intention. A large body of empirical evidence shows that a positive destination image generally increases tourist satisfaction, and that higher satisfaction further strengthens revisit intention and positive word-of-mouth (Zhang et al., 2014; Kanwel et al., 2019a).

Conceptually, this relationship exhibits a relatively clear sequential structure. Tourists first form an overall image judgment based on their perceptions of destination attributes. They then compare this judgment with their actual experience,

which affects satisfaction. Satisfaction, as a summary evaluation of the travel experience, is subsequently translated into future behavioral intentions. This classic path—destination image, satisfaction, and loyalty-related behavior—has been validated across countries and tourism types and remains highly robust in tourism behavior research.

However, two issues warrant further investigation. First, many studies treat destination image as a direct antecedent of satisfaction and revisit intention while paying limited attention to the internal cognitive layer of destination image and its antecedent sources, thereby leaving model explanations at a relatively macro level. Second, although satisfaction is often regarded as the key mediator in studies of behavioral intention, the causal logic between image and satisfaction, and the strength of this relationship in specific cultural contexts, remain insufficiently examined. In the case of Chinese tourists visiting South Korea, travel experience is shaped by multiple factors, including cultural imagination, consumption convenience, and spatial atmosphere. Re-examining this mechanism at a more fine-grained perceptual level is therefore necessary.

2.4 UGC and Tourist Perception in the Context of Digital Communication

With the rapid development of social media and online travel platforms, user-generated content (UGC) has become an important source of tourism information dissemination and destination cognition. Compared with official promotional materials, UGC is more authentic, interactive, and contextualized, and can more directly reflect tourists' subjective experiences and evaluations. For this reason, tourism research has increasingly emphasized the need to understand tourists' perceptions and cognitive processes through their own expressions in online environments.

Existing research suggests that UGC has changed not only the way tourists acquire information, but also the way destination images are produced. Traditionally, destination images were shaped largely by government publicity, tourism advertising, and travel agency information. In the digital communication environment, however, tourists increasingly construct destination perceptions through other travelers' reviews, travel notes, and social media posts. Destination image is therefore no longer fully controlled by official actors; instead, it is continuously negotiated and reconstructed through a process of tourist expression, platform diffusion, and social interpretation.

Although UGC research offers a valuable lens for understanding tourists' lived perceptions, the literature still focuses primarily on sentiment analysis, destination word-of-mouth, or single dimensions of experience. Systematic research integrating tourists' multidimensional perceptions into a formal tourism behavior model remains limited. This gap is particularly evident in the context of Chinese tourists visiting South Korea, where cultural proximity and media influence are especially salient. In this setting, destination cognition may be shaped simultaneously by landscape, history, cultural atmosphere, consumption environments, and popular-cultural symbols. Theoretical modeling therefore needs to connect real perception more directly with behavioral mechanisms.

2.5 Research Gaps and Entry Points

In summary, prior research has provided a solid basis for understanding travel motivation, destination image, and behavioral outcomes, but important opportunities for extension remain. First, although the dual structure of cognitive and affective image is widely recognized, few studies offer a detailed account of the antecedents of cognitive image, especially from the perspective of tourists' multidimensional perceptions. Second, although the relationship among destination image, satisfaction, and revisit intention has received substantial empirical support, most studies remain at the level of testing macro-level paths and do not adequately explain how specific perceptual dimensions shape later behavior through cognitive image. Third, in the digital communication context, UGC has become a major source of information that affects tourists' perceptions, yet the incorporation of experience-based perceptual information into a standardized theoretical model remains underdeveloped.

To address these gaps, this study takes Chinese tourists' travel to South Korea as its empirical context and examines how tourists' multidimensional perceptions of South Korea influence cognitive image, satisfaction, and revisit intention. Compared with prior studies, the contributions of this paper are threefold. First, it advances the study of destination image antecedents by foregrounding tourists' lived perceptions, thereby enhancing the explanatory power of the model with respect to actual travel experiences. Second, it integrates perception, cognition, and behavioral response into a unified analytical framework, enriching

the theoretical interpretation of the perception–cognition–behavior chain. Third, by situating the analysis in the context of Chinese tourists’ short-haul cross-border travel to South Korea, it provides new empirical evidence for destination image research in East Asian cultural settings.

3 Text Analysis

3.1 Text Data Sources and Preprocessing

Using travel-review texts posted by Chinese tourists about South Korea, this study employed web-crawling tools to collect reviews of South Korean attractions from online travel platforms and social media between 2015 and 2024. After preliminary screening, deduplication, and cleaning, 12,328 valid reviews were retained. The sample mainly covered Seoul and other representative tourism destinations in South Korea and captured perceptions related to landscape experience, cultural cognition, historical impression, consumption activities, and service evaluation. It therefore provides a relatively comprehensive picture of how Chinese tourists perceive South Korean destinations.

To enhance the reliability of the text analysis, the raw reviews were subjected to standardized preprocessing. Specifically, emojis, advertising messages, and other non-semantic content were removed; traditional and simplified Chinese were standardized; a small number of foreign-language comments were translated into Chinese; and duplicate or highly similar texts were excluded through text-similarity screening to ensure sample independence and validity. The cleaned corpus was then segmented using the Jieba word-segmentation tool. In addition, a supplementary dictionary tailored to South Korean tourism contexts was constructed to improve the recognition accuracy of place names, attraction names, and tourism-related specialized terms. These procedures generated a structured text corpus suitable for high-frequency word statistics and semantic induction.

3.2 High-Frequency Word Analysis and Word-Cloud Results

High-frequency word statistics and word-cloud visualization make it possible to observe more clearly the focal concerns and linguistic characteristics of Chinese tourists’ travel narratives about South Korea. Overall, the comments revolve around spatial imagery, cultural experience, landscape aesthetics, and consumption activities, indicating that Chinese tourists perceive South Korea through a distinctly multidimensional destination image.

First, in terms of spatial perception, words such as “Korea,” “Seoul,” “Myeongdong,” “Gyeongbokgung Palace,” and “Namsan Tower” appear frequently in the reviews, indicating that Seoul occupies a core position in Chinese tourists’ mental maps of South Korea. By repeatedly referring to specific landmarks, districts, and attractions, tourists form an overall impression of Korea as a place where tradition and modernity coexist. Historical and cultural spaces such as Gyeongbokgung Palace and hanok villages reinforce the image of traditional culture, while urban landmarks such as Myeongdong and Seoul Tower evoke modern urbanity and popular-culture symbolism. This suggests that tourists’ perceptions of Korea are not limited to an abstract national image, but are gradually constructed through concrete spatial experiences.

Second, in terms of experience content, high-frequency words such as “shopping,” “night,” “cable car,” “architecture,” and “place” indicate that shopping, night-view experiences, and urban touring are central components of Chinese tourists’ South Korea trips. The frequent appearance of shopping-related vocabulary suggests that consumption activities remain an important driver of travel to South Korea. Words associated with night views, cable cars, and architecture further imply that tourists pay attention not only to attractions themselves, but also to the atmosphere, convenience, and shareability of the experience. In other words, tourists’ narratives portray South Korean travel as a compound experience that combines sightseeing, consumption, and emotion.

Third, in terms of value judgment, words such as “worth,” “many,” “here,” and “can” appear frequently, suggesting that tourists generally hold positive evaluations of South Korea’s tourism resources. Such expressions not only reflect recognition of destination accessibility and experiential value, but also imply a tendency toward recommendation and secondary dissemination. In the context of UGC, these evaluative expressions possess strong social-diffusion characteristics: while tourists narrate their personal experiences, they also participate in the reproduction and word-of-mouth promotion of destination

image.

Overall, the word-cloud and high-frequency word results indicate that Chinese tourists' perceptions of South Korean destinations are highly comprehensive, encompassing both cognitive evaluations of scenery, history, and culture and emotional responses to romantic atmosphere, consumption convenience, and the overall travel experience. These results provide the empirical basis for identifying the core perceptual dimensions and constructing the subsequent structural model.

3.3 Identification of Core Perceptual Dimensions

Based on the high-frequency word statistics and semantic induction results, this study further summarizes Chinese tourists' perceptions of South Korea into five core dimensions: perceived romance, perceived culture, perceived history, perceived landscape, and perceived consumption. These five dimensions capture the main sources from which Chinese tourists construct South Korea's destination image and therefore provide the basis for specifying the key variables in the subsequent empirical model.

Perceived romance primarily refers to tourists' emotional associations with South Korea's urban atmosphere, Korean Wave narratives, and couple-oriented scenes. Seoul Tower, the Han River, and nighttime urban spaces are repeatedly described as "romantic," "dreamlike," or "ideal for dating," suggesting that South Korea carries strong affective and symbolic meaning for Chinese tourists.

Perceived culture is reflected mainly in tourists' attention to Korea's traditional culture and everyday aesthetics, including hanok, traditional districts, café culture, street shops, and artistic ambience. Tourists do not remain at the superficial level of cultural symbols; rather, they tend to form their understanding of Korean culture through participatory and experience-based encounters.

Perceived history refers mainly to the historical impression and cultural identity tourists develop when visiting heritage sites such as Gyeongbokgung Palace. Historical spaces not only reinforce the cultural depth of South Korean destinations, but also enable tourists to develop more concrete perceptions of the destination through cross-cultural comparison.

Perceived landscape reflects tourists' aesthetic evaluations of South Korea's urban environment, natural scenery, and overall visual experience. Compared with specific landmark-based perceptions, this dimension emphasizes holistic impressions and captures tourists' summary feelings that the destination is beautiful, tidy, comfortable, and worth visiting.

Perceived consumption reflects tourists' evaluations of the shopping environment, product variety, payment convenience, and commercial atmosphere in South Korea. Spaces such as Myeongdong and Dongdaemun are not merely shopping sites, but also integral parts of the overall tourism experience, illustrating the close connection between tourism consumption and cultural experience.

Table 3-1. Core Perceptual Dimensions Extracted from the Text Analysis

Core dimension	Main connotation	Representative keywords/scenes
Perceived romance	Emotional associations triggered by urban nightscapes, couple-oriented experiences, and Korean Wave narratives	Seoul Tower; Han River; night views; couples; romance
Perceived culture	Traditional districts, hanok, aesthetic spaces, and everyday cultural experiences	Bukchon Hanok Village; Samcheong-dong; Insadong; cafes; arts/culture
Perceived history	Historical cognition shaped by heritage sites, palace architecture, and traditional rituals	Gyeongbokgung Palace; palaces; hanbok; history; plaza
Perceived landscape	Aesthetic evaluations of the urban environment, natural scenery, and overall visual experience	scenery; landscape; architecture; clean; comfortable
Perceived consumption	Consumption experiences created by shopping convenience, product variety, and commercial atmosphere	Myeongdong; shopping; cosmetics; street food; clothing

3.4 Summary of Text Analysis

The text-analysis results show that Chinese tourists' perceptions of South Korea as a tourism destination are not one-dimensional; rather, they consist of multiple elements, including romance, culture, history, landscape, and consumption. Overall, South Korea's destination image in the minds of Chinese tourists is characterized by emotional appeal, cultural recognition, and

consumption convenience, which together reflect the typical advantages of a short-haul cross-border destination.

More specifically, the five dimensions correspond to different layers of the tourist experience. Perceived romance reflects emotional projection and affective satisfaction; perceived culture and perceived history represent cultural cognition and meaning construction; perceived landscape corresponds to overall environmental evaluation; and perceived consumption reflects both economic and social-interaction experiences. Taken together, these dimensions form the cognitive structure through which Chinese tourists understand South Korean destinations and provide the content foundation and variable support for examining the relationship among multidimensional perception, cognitive image, satisfaction, and revisit intention.

4 Research Design

4.1 Theoretical Model and Research Hypotheses

Drawing on destination image theory, the satisfaction–loyalty framework, and the preceding text-analysis results, this study develops a research model linking multidimensional perception, cognitive image, satisfaction, and revisit intention. Specifically, perceived romance, perceived landscape, perceived culture, perceived history, and perceived consumption are treated as five key destination attributes perceived by tourists in South Korea. Cognitive image reflects tourists' overall rational evaluation of the destination, satisfaction captures their overall affective judgment after the travel experience, and revisit intention represents their future tendency to revisit and recommend the destination.

First, tourists' positive perceptions of destination attributes are expected to translate into a clearer and more favorable cognitive image. Whether through romantic atmosphere, landscape quality, cultural characteristics, historical resources, or consumption convenience, these attributes provide the core cues through which tourists understand the attractiveness and uniqueness of the destination. Accordingly, this study proposes that all five perceptual dimensions positively influence cognitive image.

Second, positive perceptions of destination attributes are expected not only to shape cognitive evaluations, but also to directly enhance satisfaction. High-quality landscape experiences, distinctive cultural and historical resources, a favorable consumption environment, and a romantic atmosphere can all strengthen tourists' positive evaluations of their overall travel experience. At the same time, cognitive image, as the overarching framework through which tourists evaluate the destination, is expected to further influence satisfaction.

Finally, cognitive image and satisfaction are widely regarded as key predictors of subsequent tourist behavior. A positive cognitive image can reduce uncertainty in future decisions and increase willingness to revisit, whereas higher satisfaction is typically translated into repeat visitation, recommendations, and positive word-of-mouth. Accordingly, this study further specifies the direct effects of cognitive image and satisfaction on revisit intention and examines the mediating roles of cognitive image and satisfaction between multidimensional perception and revisit intention.

Table 4-1. Summary of Research Hypotheses

Category	Hypothesis	Statement
Multidimensional perception → cognitive image	H1	Perceived romance positively influences cognitive image.
	H2	Perceived landscape positively influences cognitive image.
	H3	Perceived culture positively influences cognitive image.
	H4	Perceived history positively influences cognitive image.
	H5	Perceived consumption positively influences cognitive image.
Multidimensional perception → satisfaction	H6	Perceived romance positively influences satisfaction.
	H7	Perceived landscape positively influences satisfaction.
	H8	Perceived culture positively influences satisfaction.
	H9	Perceived history positively influences satisfaction.
	H10	Perceived consumption positively influences satisfaction.
Cognitive image, satisfaction, and revisit intention	H11	Cognitive image positively influences satisfaction.
	H12	Cognitive image positively influences revisit intention.
	H13	Satisfaction positively influences revisit intention.

Mediating effects	H14a–	Cognitive image mediates the relationships between perceived romance, perceived landscape, perceived culture, perceived history, perceived consumption, and revisit intention, respectively.
	H14e	
	H15a–	Satisfaction mediates the relationships between perceived romance, perceived landscape, perceived culture, perceived history, perceived consumption, and revisit intention, respectively.
	H15e	
	H16	Satisfaction mediates the relationship between cognitive image and revisit intention.

4.2 Variable Measurement and Questionnaire Design

This study contextualized its measurement items by drawing on established scales and integrating the five perceptual dimensions identified in the preceding text analysis. To ensure semantic equivalence, the questionnaire underwent a back-translation procedure: the Chinese version was first translated by two doctoral students majoring in English and then reviewed and revised by two marketing scholars. All items were measured on a five-point Likert scale, where 1 indicated “strongly disagree” and 5 indicated “strongly agree.”

Among the variables, the scales for perceived romance, perceived landscape, perceived culture, perceived history, and perceived consumption were developed from the text-analysis results and representative review expressions. The cognitive image scale was adapted from Liang et al. (2023), the satisfaction scale from Zhao et al. (2024), and the revisit intention scale from Carvache-Franco et al. (2025).

Table 4-2. Measurement Items

Construct	Code	Measurement item	Source
Perceived romance (PR)	PR1	This destination offers a romantic atmosphere.	Developed from the preceding text
	PR2	The cafés and neighborhood ambience here create a romantic experience.	Same as above
	PR3	Traveling here makes me feel romantic emotions.	Same as above
Perceived landscape (PS)	PS1	The natural scenery of this destination is impressive.	Developed from the preceding text
	PS2	The attractions are well organized and provide a good touring experience.	Same as above
	PS3	The combination of natural and cultural scenery creates a unique sightseeing experience.	Same as above
Perceived culture (PC)	PC1	The local traditional culture is attractive.	Developed from the preceding text
	PC2	The local food left a deep impression on me.	Same as above
	PC3	This trip enhanced my understanding of local cultural traditions and values.	Same as above
Perceived history (PH)	PH1	Historical sites are attractive.	Developed from the preceding text
	PH2	Visiting historical sites improved my understanding of local history.	Same as above
	PH3	Historical heritage added unique value to my travel experience.	Same as above
Perceived consumption (PCV)	PCV1	Overall travel expenses were reasonable.	Developed from the preceding text
	PCV2	I was satisfied with the shopping experience.	Same as above
	PCV3	This trip felt worth the money.	Same as above
Cognitive image (CI)	CI1	This destination has interesting historical and cultural attractions.	Liang et al. (2023)
	CI2	Local residents are friendly and approachable.	Same as above
	CI3	The local climate is comfortable.	Same as above
Satisfaction (SAT)	SAT1	This trip met my expectations.	Zhao et al. (2024)
	SAT2	I am satisfied with my overall impression of this trip.	Same as above
	SAT3	Compared with other travel experiences, this trip made me more satisfied.	Same as above
Revisit intention (RI)	RI1	I am willing to recommend this destination to others.	Carvache-Franco et al. (2025)
	RI2	I plan to revisit this destination in the future.	Same as above
	RI3	I would speak positively about this destination.	Same as above

4.3 Data Collection and Sample Characteristics

This study focused on Chinese tourists who had traveled to South Korea and conducted an online questionnaire survey through the Wenjuanxing platform in August 2025. The questionnaire included demographic items and latent-variable measurement items. A total of 630 responses were collected. To ensure data quality, the study excluded questionnaires completed in less than five minutes, cases with highly homogeneous answers or obvious logical contradictions, and respondents without actual travel experience in South Korea. Ultimately, 578 valid responses were retained, yielding an effective response

rate of 91.7%.

The sample size met the requirements of PLS-SEM and was substantially higher than the minimum sample-size rule of ten times the number of latent variables. Overall, the sample displayed variation across gender, age, income, and education and therefore captured the basic structural characteristics of Chinese tourists visiting South Korea. Specifically, female respondents slightly outnumbered male respondents; most respondents were between 25 and 34 years old; income was concentrated in the middle-income group; and the majority held at least a bachelor's degree. This profile is broadly consistent with the characteristics of young, highly educated, and consumption-oriented tourists in the South Korean tourism market.

Table 4-3. Sample Characteristics (N = 578)

Variable	Category	Frequency	Share
Gender	Male	265	45.80%
	Female	313	54.20%
Age	24 years or below	165	28.50%
	25–34 years	251	43.40%
	35–44 years	85	14.70%
	45 years or above	77	13.30%
Annual income (USD)	Below 7,000	171	29.60%
	7,001–10,000	257	44.50%
	10,001–13,500	73	12.60%
	13,501–17,000	52	9.00%
	Above 17,001	25	4.30%
Education	High school or below	159	27.50%
	Junior college	111	19.20%
	Bachelor's degree	241	41.70%
	Graduate degree or above	67	11.60%

5 Empirical Results and Hypothesis Testing

5.1 Measurement Model Results

This study first assessed the reliability, convergent validity, and discriminant validity of the measurement model to verify that the latent constructs were measured in a stable and valid manner. The results show that the standardized loadings of all items exceeded 0.70, indicating strong explanatory power for their respective constructs. Cronbach's alpha values ranged from 0.767 to 0.875, composite reliability (CR) values ranged from 0.865 to 0.923, and average variance extracted (AVE) values ranged from 0.682 to 0.800; all of these values exceeded the recommended thresholds. In addition, all VIF values were well below 3.30, suggesting that multicollinearity was not a concern. Overall, the measurement model demonstrates satisfactory internal consistency and convergent validity.

Table 5-1. Reliability and Convergent Validity of the Measurement Model

Construct	Item	Loading	VIF	Cronbach's α	CR	AVE
Perceived romance (PR)	PR1	0.887	2.471	0.854	0.911	0.773
	PR2	0.875	2.011			
	PR3	0.875	2.035			
Perceived landscape (PS)	PS1	0.831	1.691	0.767	0.865	0.682
	PS2	0.838	1.659			
	PS3	0.808	1.429			
Perceived culture (PC)	PC1	0.848	1.804	0.815	0.890	0.730
	PC2	0.872	1.977			
	PC3	0.842	1.692			
Perceived history (PH)	PH1	0.880	1.960	0.802	0.883	0.715
	PH2	0.805	1.662			
	PH3	0.851	1.667			

Perceived consumption (PCV)	PCV1	0.880	1.840	0.812	0.888	0.726
	PCV2	0.825	1.671			
	PCV3	0.851	1.873			
Cognitive image (CI)	CI1	0.845	1.734	0.826	0.896	0.742
	CI2	0.869	1.983			
	CI3	0.870	1.955			
Satisfaction (SAT)	SAT1	0.912	2.641	0.875	0.923	0.800
	SAT2	0.898	2.558			
	SAT3	0.873	2.079			
Revisit intention (RI)	RI1	0.871	2.054	0.850	0.909	0.769
	RI2	0.879	2.081			
	RI3	0.881	2.080			

To assess discriminant validity, this study applied both the Fornell–Larcker criterion and the heterotrait–monotrait ratio (HTMT). The Fornell–Larcker results show that the square root of AVE for each construct exceeded its correlations with the other constructs, indicating adequate construct distinctiveness. Likewise, all HTMT values were below the commonly recommended threshold of 0.90, further supporting discriminant validity. In terms of global model fit, the SRMR was 0.057, which is below the conventional cutoff of 0.08 and indicates a good fit between the model and the observed data.

Table 5-2. Discriminant Validity and Model Fit

(1) Fornell–Larcker criterion								
Construct	CI	PC	PCV	PH	PR	PS		
CI	0.861							
PC	0.567	0.854						
PCV	0.452	0.342	0.852					
PH	0.521	0.322	0.324	0.846				
PR	0.431	0.315	0.135	0.294	0.879			
PS	0.481	0.455	0.315	0.277	0.124	0.826		
(2) HTMT ratio								
Construct	CI	PC	PCV	PH	PR	PS	RI	SAT
CI	—							
PC	0.465	—						
PCV	0.374	0.278	—					
PH	0.427	0.261	0.263	—				
PR	0.367	0.266	0.117	0.246	—			
PS	0.384	0.359	0.249	0.217	0.104	—		
RI	0.522	0.404	0.331	0.438	0.407	0.366	—	
SAT	0.273	0.295	0.268	0.339	0.313	0.246	0.522	—
(3) Model-fit indicator								
Indicator		Value			Assessment			
SRMR		0.057			Good fit			

In terms of explanatory power, the adjusted R^2 values for cognitive image, satisfaction, and revisit intention were 0.415, 0.222, and 0.425, respectively. These results indicate moderate explanatory power for cognitive image and revisit intention and weak but acceptable explanatory power for satisfaction. Further examination of effect sizes (f^2) shows that the effects of cognitive image on revisit intention and satisfaction on revisit intention were both moderate ($f^2 = 0.271$), whereas the effects of the various perceptual variables on cognitive image and satisfaction were mostly small. This finding suggests that revisit intention is driven primarily by the two proximal variables of cognitive image and satisfaction, whereas multidimensional perception influences behavioral intention more indirectly through prior evaluative processes.

Table 5-3. Explanatory Power and Effect Sizes

(1) Explanatory power of endogenous variables

Endogenous variable	Adjusted R ²	Endogenous variable	Adjusted R ²	Endogenous variable	Adjusted R ²
Cognitive image (CI)	0.415	Satisfaction (SAT)	0.222	Revisit intention (RI)	0.425

(2) Effect sizes (f²)

Path	f ²	Path	f ²	Path	f ²
CI→RI	0.271	PCV→SAT	0.022	PS→CI	0.049
CI→SAT	0.002	PH→CI	0.076	PS→SAT	0.014
PC→CI	0.074	PH→SAT	0.047	SAT→RI	0.271
PC→SAT	0.015	PR→CI	0.067		
PCV→CI	0.047	PR→SAT	0.052		

5.2 Structural Model and Mediation Analysis

In the structural-model assessment, this study employed bootstrapping with 5,000 resamples to evaluate the significance of the path coefficients. The results show that all five perceptual variables had significant positive effects on cognitive image: perceived romance ($\beta = 0.208$, $p < 0.001$), perceived landscape ($\beta = 0.184$, $p < 0.001$), perceived culture ($\beta = 0.235$, $p < 0.001$), perceived history ($\beta = 0.228$, $p < 0.001$), and perceived consumption ($\beta = 0.178$, $p < 0.001$). In relative terms, perceived culture and perceived history exerted slightly stronger effects than the other dimensions, suggesting that cultural and historical attributes occupy a particularly central position in Chinese tourists' cognitive construction of South Korea as a destination.

All five perceptual variables also had significant positive effects on satisfaction. Among them, perceived romance ($\beta = 0.218$, $p < 0.001$) and perceived history ($\beta = 0.213$, $p < 0.001$) had relatively stronger effects, indicating that emotional atmosphere and historically grounded cultural content are especially important for enhancing overall satisfaction. By contrast, the effects of perceived landscape ($\beta = 0.118$, $p = 0.003$) and perceived culture ($\beta = 0.124$, $p = 0.002$) were significant but comparatively weaker.

Furthermore, satisfaction had a significant positive effect on revisit intention ($\beta = 0.410$, $p < 0.001$), and cognitive image also had a significant positive effect on revisit intention ($\beta = 0.410$, $p < 0.001$). However, the effect of cognitive image on satisfaction was not significant ($\beta = -0.055$, $p = 0.273$), indicating that, in this study, tourists' overall rational evaluation of South Korea does not automatically translate into higher satisfaction. Instead, satisfaction appears to be driven more directly by specific experiential dimensions. Accordingly, H1–H10, H12, and H13 were supported, whereas H11 was not supported.

Table 5-4. Direct Effects Test Results

Hyp.	Path	β	M	SD	t	p	Result
H1	PR→CI	0.208	0.208	0.029	7.072	0.000***	Supported
H2	PS→CI	0.184	0.185	0.033	5.509	0.000***	Supported
H3	PC→CI	0.235	0.235	0.034	6.875	0.000***	Supported
H4	PH→CI	0.228	0.228	0.034	6.695	0.000***	Supported
H5	PCV→CI	0.178	0.179	0.035	5.154	0.000***	Supported
H6	PR→SAT	0.218	0.219	0.037	5.906	0.000***	Supported
H7	PS→SAT	0.118	0.119	0.040	2.940	0.003**	Supported
H8	PC→SAT	0.124	0.126	0.041	3.034	0.002**	Supported
H9	PH→SAT	0.213	0.213	0.041	5.149	0.000***	Supported
H10	PCV→SAT	0.143	0.144	0.036	4.006	0.000***	Supported
H11	CI→SAT	-0.055	-0.056	0.050	1.095	0.273	Not supported
H12	CI→RI	0.410	0.411	0.031	13.343	0.000***	Supported
H13	SAT→RI	0.410	0.410	0.028	14.831	0.000***	Supported

Note: *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$

For the mediation analysis, this study followed the recommendations of Preacher and Hayes (2008) and Zhao et al. (2010) and again used bootstrap estimation with 5,000 resamples. The results show that satisfaction significantly mediated the relationships between all five perceptual variables and revisit intention. Specifically, perceived romance, landscape, culture, history, and consumption indirectly promoted revisit intention through satisfaction. At the same time, cognitive image also served as a significant mediator between each perceptual dimension and revisit intention.

By contrast, the chain-mediating effect of cognitive image on revisit intention through satisfaction was not significant ($\beta = -0.022$, $p = 0.280$). This result is consistent with the previously non-significant path from cognitive image to satisfaction and suggests that cognitive image and satisfaction are better understood as two relatively parallel mediating mechanisms rather than as a strictly sequential transmission chain.

Table 5-5. Mediation Test Results

Hyp.	Mediation path	β	M	SD	t	p	Result
H14a	PR→CI→RI	0.085	0.086	0.015	5.841	0.000***	Supported
H14b	PS→CI→RI	0.075	0.076	0.015	4.958	0.000***	Supported
H14c	PC→CI→RI	0.096	0.096	0.016	6.060	0.000***	Supported
H14d	PH→CI→RI	0.093	0.094	0.016	5.902	0.000***	Supported
H14e	PCV→CI→RI	0.073	0.074	0.015	4.760	0.000***	Supported
H15a	PR→SAT→RI	0.089	0.090	0.017	5.193	0.000***	Supported
H15b	PS→SAT→RI	0.048	0.049	0.017	2.814	0.005**	Supported
H15c	PC→SAT→RI	0.051	0.052	0.017	2.927	0.003**	Supported
H15d	PH→SAT→RI	0.087	0.087	0.018	4.786	0.000***	Supported
H15e	PCV→SAT→RI	0.059	0.059	0.015	3.817	0.000***	Supported
H16	CI→SAT→RI	-0.022	-0.023	0.021	1.080	0.280	Not supported

Note: *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$.

Overall, the empirical results indicate that Chinese tourists' willingness to revisit South Korea is shaped mainly by two mechanisms: a rational evaluative path of multidimensional perception–cognitive image–revisit intention and an affective evaluative path of multidimensional perception–satisfaction–revisit intention. Both pathways are robustly supported, whereas the sequential chain of cognitive image–satisfaction–revisit intention is not. These findings imply that, although both cognitive image and satisfaction significantly explain revisit intention in the South Korean travel context, there is no stable sequential transmission relationship between them. Rather than treating satisfaction solely as an outcome of cognitive image, this study suggests that the two operate as parallel mediators jointly activated by multidimensional perception and independently transmitted to revisit intention.

Table 5-6. Summary of Hypothesis Testing

Hypothesis	Path	Result	Hypothesis	Path	Result
H1	PR→CI	Supported	H13	SAT→RI	Supported
H2	PS→CI	Supported	H14a	PR→CI→RI	Supported
H3	PC→CI	Supported	H14b	PS→CI→RI	Supported
H4	PH→CI	Supported	H14c	PC→CI→RI	Supported
H5	PCV→CI	Supported	H14d	PH→CI→RI	Supported
H6	PR→SAT	Supported	H14e	PCV→CI→RI	Supported
H7	PS→SAT	Supported	H15a	PR→SAT→RI	Supported
H8	PC→SAT	Supported	H15b	PS→SAT→RI	Supported
H9	PH→SAT	Supported	H15c	PC→SAT→RI	Supported
H10	PCV→SAT	Supported	H15d	PH→SAT→RI	Supported
H11	CI→SAT	Not supported	H15e	PCV→SAT→RI	Supported
H12	CI→RI	Supported	H16	CI→SAT→RI	Not supported

6 Conclusion

The findings indicate that Chinese tourists' revisit intention toward South Korea is not driven by a single destination attribute or a single causal path. Rather, it emerges from a multidimensional mechanism in which perceptual experience, overall evaluation, and behavioral intention jointly interact. The empirical results show that perceived romance, perceived landscape, perceived culture, perceived history, and perceived consumption all exert significant positive effects on both cognitive image and satisfaction. This suggests that tourists' evaluations of South Korea are rooted simultaneously in rational judgments about

destination attributes and in affective responses generated during the travel experience. Among these dimensions, perceived culture and perceived history have relatively stronger effects on cognitive image, highlighting the importance of South Korea's cultural recognizability and historical depth in forming overall destination impressions among Chinese tourists. Perceived romance and perceived history, meanwhile, play more prominent roles in enhancing satisfaction, underscoring the importance of emotional atmosphere and immersive cultural-historical experience in the overall travel experience.

At the same time, both cognitive image and satisfaction significantly enhance revisit intention, whereas the direct effect of cognitive image on satisfaction is not significant and the chain-mediating path of cognitive image–satisfaction–revisit intention is unsupported. This suggests that, in the context of Chinese tourists visiting South Korea, cognitive image and satisfaction are better understood as two parallel rather than strictly progressive pathways: the former reflects tourists' overall rational evaluations formed on the basis of destination attributes, while the latter captures their affective summary judgments of actual experience. Multidimensional perception therefore influences later behavioral choices through both the perception–cognitive image–revisit intention pathway and the perception–satisfaction–revisit intention pathway. Beyond confirming the applicability of destination image theory in the context of short-haul cross-border tourism, this study also clarifies the dual-path mechanism through which specific perceptions are translated into overall evaluation and then into behavioral intention, thereby providing more robust empirical evidence for understanding Chinese tourists' psychological formation process and for informing destination management practice in South Korea.

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